Qianwen (Kaia) Gao

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RESEARCH INTERESTS

I study how AI agents ground language and reasoning through perception and action, and whether their apparent reasoning faithfully reflects what drives their behavior. Building on behavioral evaluation, I seek to develop interpretable embodied agents that integrate language, memory, commonsense reasoning, and planning, with decisions testable through intervention and actions open to human guidance and correction.

EDUCATION

University of California, Berkeley 2025 - 2026
Master of Computational Social Science | GPA: 3.87/4.00

Zhejiang University 2021 - 2025
Bachelor of Arts, Communication | GPA: 3.95/4.00

PUBLICATION

CHASE: How Content Ecosystems Are Reshaped When Ranking Is the Only Target

Qianwen Gao, Zichang Su, Yiwen Hou, Arlen Kumar, Leanid Palkhouski. *Conference on Language Modeling (COLM)*, 2026. Poster presentation. arXiv:2608.30466.

RESEARCH AND EVALUATION EXPERIENCE

Wrodium | AI Research Intern Dec 2025 - Jul 2026

Co-authored CHASE, a simulation-based evaluation of how optimizing content for LLM rankings reshapes content ecosystems across six domains and weakens alignment with independently assessed quality.

Led FreshRAG evaluation design: built temporal QA data from factual changes and designed controlled comparisons of knowledge conflict, temporal grounding, and parametric override.

Oakland Natives Give Back (ONGB) & Wizearly | ML Capstone Feb - May 2026

Built a leakage-safe early-warning pipeline using 256,865 student-year records from 36,695 students across seven years; engineered 63 attendance, academic, demographic, school, and neighborhood features.

Compared eight models with class imbalance-aware training, cross-validation, and a temporal holdout; tuned XGBoost reached 0.734 PR-AUC and 98.9% recall.

Examined intervention thresholds, retaining 94.5% recall while reducing false positives by about 22% versus the default threshold to support school leaders' decisions.

SELECTED PROJECTS

PickMem | Independent project 2026

Built a local-first LLM memory-curation application with semantic retrieval, making stored context easier for users to inspect and manage.

Amazon Fashion Review Sentiment Analysis | Team course project 2025

Analyzed approximately 831,000 reviews with topic modeling and aspect-based sentiment analysis to identify themes and product attributes associated with ratings.

METHODS AND TOOLS

Methods: LLM evaluation, NLP, retrieval-augmented generation, experimental design, causal inference, regression.
Programming and tools: Python, SQL, R, TypeScript; pandas, scikit-learn, PyTorch, Git.
Robotics tools (introductory): MuJoCo, robosuite, robomimic.